Energy

One-page brief

Priority: 11 of 33 (score 3.3). **FY2026 outlays:** $63B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27. Public data only.

Bottom line

Most DOE money goes to national lab operating contractors and nuclear cleanup, which are hard to score from outside. The fraud-prone slice is the fast-growing grant, loan and small business research money from the 2021 infrastructure law and 2022 Inflation Reduction Act: many new recipients, large awards, and thin track records. That is where public award data and the SBA entity checks fit.

Exposure

- $63B in outlays and $141B in budgetary resources in FY2026, swollen by multi-year infrastructure and clean energy appropriations.
- DOE is one of the largest SBIR/STTR funders. GAO found almost 8% of SBIR and STTR awardees had four or more fraud risk indicators and about $445M in possibly duplicative awards across agencies (2024).
- DOE does not report a high-risk improper payment program.

Public data we can use

- **USAspending and FPDS:** grants, cooperative agreements, contracts and subawards by recipient.
- **SBIR.gov award data:** firm, PI, abstract and agency for every award.
- **DOE Loan Programs Office portfolio** listings.
- **SAM.gov** entity and exclusion records; DOE OIG reports.

Detection plays

1. **Duplicate research awards:** near-identical SBIR abstracts funded by DOE and other agencies (text similarity across SBIR.gov).
2. **Thin recipients, big awards:** new entities winning large grants, shared addresses across "independent" applicants, and pass-through subawards.
3. **Excluded links:** recipients or principal investigators tied to excluded parties or prior settlements.

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First prototype

A cross-agency SBIR duplicate-award screen covering DOE, NSF, NASA and DoD. It is cheap (one public data set) and serves four briefs at once.

Limits

Lab and cleanup contractor costs are not visible below the award level. Duplicate abstracts are leads; some overlap is legitimate.

Who to take it to

DOE OIG, DOE Office of Science SBIR/STTR program office, and the SBA SBIR program office.

Sources

- GAO-24-105470: SBIR/STTR fraud vulnerabilities (Sept 2024)
- SBIR.gov awards data
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)